

The Most Important Promises

9/8/2024 — 10/6/2024

Overview

This series explores what it means to be a true disciple of Jesus Christ. It emphasizes that discipleship is not just about belief or admiration but involves active following and commitment to Jesus' teachings and example. This five-week series focuses on the promises of prayer, presence, gifts, service, and witness, which are the commitments made by members of the church. Through relatable stories and scriptural references, it underscores the importance of these commitments in cultivating a genuine, heartfelt relationship with Jesus.

This series will challenge the congregation to examine their own commitments and relationship with Jesus. It encourages them to embrace the path of discipleship by making deliberate and prayerful decisions about their promises to God and the church. The message is clear: true discipleship requires action, sacrifice, and a willingness to follow Jesus wherever He leads. By committing to the five vows, members can grow closer to Jesus and, consequently, closer to one another, fostering unity and love within the church community. The pathway of a disciple is a journey of deep faith and dedication. Through this series we will invite the congregation to actively participate in the transformative process of discipleship.

Each sermon should accomplish these objectives:

- Articulate one of the five membership vows and explain why it is important.
- Help define why being a member of the church matters.
- Offer the congregation tangible ways to improve on their membership vows.
- Elicit a response from members by submitting a pledge card.

Sermon Schedule

Sunday	Sermon Title	Scripture	Supplemental Scriptures	Notes Or Ideas
9/8/24	We Promise to Pray	Luke 11:1-13	Luke 9:18-23, Isaiah 42 1-4, Isaiah 61;1-3	
9/15/24	We Promise to Be Present	John 17:13-23	Luke 9:18-23, Isaiah 11;1-9	
9/22/24	We Promise to Give	Matthew 6:19-27	Luke 9:18-23, Isaiah 35;1-10	
9/29/24	We Promise to Serve	John 13:1-15	Luke 9:18-23, Micah 5;2-5a	
10/6/24	We Promise our Witness	John 3:1-15	Luke 9:18-23, Luke 2;1-20	

Week 1 | We Promise Our Prayers

This sermon focuses on the importance of prayer in the life of a disciple. Many people misunderstand what it means to have a strong prayer life. Good prayer requires dedicated time, a reliable guide, and a committed response, suggesting that prayer is not about control or technique but about drawing closer to Jesus. The sermon highlights the necessity of daily, intentional prayer and offers various methods to help cultivate this practice, underscoring that true prayer transforms us and must be shared. The ultimate goal is to develop a prayer-filled life that genuinely seeks Christ, leading to a deeper relationship with God and a transformative impact on the world.

Week 2 | We Promise Our Presence

In this sermon, the focus is on the importance of presence within the church community, as derived from John 17 and the membership vows of the United Methodist Church. The sermon emphasizes that true Christian unity and holiness cannot be achieved in isolation but through genuine relationships within the church. Drawing from Jesus' prayer for unity in John 17, it highlights the necessity of fellowship within the church, where individuals can truly know and support each other. The sermon calls for a commitment to presence, not just in attending church services but in actively participating in discipleship to form deep, accountable relationships that reflect the unity Jesus prayed for.

Week 3 | We Promise Our Gifts

In this sermon, the focus is on the practice of giving as an essential part of discipleship, rooted in biblical principles and the Methodist tradition. It begins with a story about a Lutheran church in Minneapolis that has embraced the joyful and expressive giving practices of its new Liberian members, illustrating how giving can be a profound act of worship and joy. The sermon emphasizes that while generosity is an attractive quality, many people struggle with doubts about its impact and their capacity to give. It explores the concept of Mammon as a spiritual force that can possess us, contrasting it with the transformative power of God's grace. The practice of tithing, or giving a tenth of one's income, is highlighted as a longstanding tradition that helps break the hold of materialism and aligns believers with God's generosity. Through personal anecdotes and examples, the sermon underscores that generosity is not about achieving wealth but about embodying the grace of a generous God, ultimately transforming both the giver and the community.

Week 4 | We Promise Our Service

In this sermon, the focus is on the Christian call to service, emphasizing that while rights are important, the true essence of following Christ involves humility and serving others. The sermon begins by reflecting on the Declaration of Independence and its focus on unalienable rights, contrasting this with Jesus' teachings which emphasize love, mercy, and service over personal rights. Using the example of Jesus washing his disciples' feet, it illustrates that genuine service often means giving up our perceived rights and status. The sermon encourages the congregation to engage in acts of common courtesy as starting points for service and highlights that true Christian service requires going beyond minimal acts of kindness. Service is portrayed as a means of grace, a way to encounter God's transformative power. The sermon concludes by urging the congregation to commit to serving within the church and in the broader community, stressing that through service, individuals can experience and share the love, forgiveness, and kindness of God.

Week 5 | We Promise Our Witness

In this sermon, the focus is on the importance of witnessing as part of the disciple's path, highlighting the final membership vow of the United Methodist Church. The sermon begins by challenging the congregation to reimagine a disciple's path as a beam of light, emphasizing the transformative difference between merely looking at the light and walking in it. Through the story of Nicodemus, who meets Jesus at night, the sermon illustrates the necessity of stepping into the light to truly understand and experience God's kingdom. Witnessing is presented not as an act of interrogation but as living a life so transformed by Christ that others cannot help but notice and inquire. The sermon calls the congregation to commit to their church and community, underscoring that true witness involves visible, faithful living that reflects Christ's love and grace. It concludes by urging members to recommit or make a new commitment to their vows, emphasizing the collective impact of their individual actions on the body of Christ.